

# 'A VERY, VERY SPECIAL PRESENT'

The legendary **Vijay Amritraj** who was inducted into the Tennis Hall of Fame shares his thoughts.

N. Sudarshan

sudarshan.narayanan@thehindu.co.in

**V**ijay Amritraj is a man of many talents. A successful player, broadcaster, commentator, administrator — the list is endless. It then came as no surprise when the Indian great was inducted into the Tennis Hall of Fame (contributor category) in December 2023. In an interview with *Sportstar*, the 70-year-old speaks about a recognition that "highlights his career from the time he was 7 to 70."

## What does the award mean to you?

First and foremost, the fact is that I played this game for a long time. I've been very blessed to have played the Davis Cup for 20 years, at the highest level, singles and doubles, and led India to two Davis Cup finals (1974 and 1987). I have played with a fever and injuries after surgery too... The adrenaline kind of gets you to do all these things. More so when you had a very, very strong connection to the Davis Cup and Wimbledon and how Indians felt about these two [competitions]. On court, you're always an Indian, and that Tricolour is going to come out, and the anthem is going to be played. To me, that mattered just as much as

winning. And I carried that [feeling] post my playing career as well.

In 2022, I was awarded the Golden Achievement Award (for 2021) by the International Tennis Federation (ITF) and the International Tennis Hall of Fame (ITHF). It was for those who contributed to the sport [in administration, promotion, education, etc.]. That was a big occasion, and I don't think a player had won that before. And there were a lot of people who felt that I should have been in the Hall of Fame earlier. But it doesn't quite work that way. It's more a question of how your peers, past players, writers, journalists, and administrators who vote feel. If you have made a difference to the sport, represented your country and the sport with integrity, doing things for the game worldwide. The [Hall of Fame] award kind of highlights that, and it came a day before my 70th birthday. So, it was a very, very special present.

**You have joined the likes of John Barrett (former player and Wimbledon commentator), Nick Bollettieri (celebrated coach), and other illustrious names. How does that feel?**

The contributor category is very, very special to me. It is not easily given. You have to be in this for a long time and earn your right by making a difference to the sport by either writing about it, being on television or in administration, and so forth. Needless to say, my tennis career was the first part of it, and my contribution continued thereafter. But all of it together is what enhances the package. From the time I played for the first time overseas, there was no Indian professional athlete at that time. So, the things that I did reflected on all Indians. I came from a unique place because tennis was a sport of the West at the time. So, all those things mattered.

**Looking back at your playing career, you reached two Davis Cup finals, made singles quarters at Slams, won more than a dozen titles on the Tour, and were in the top-20. When you started as a child, did you ever imagine achieving any of these?**

Oh, my goodness! Far from it. The dream was to be able to get healthy and go to school. I was not healthy and was a bad student. My mother sat in class for me to take notes and